Multilevel Reading Practice

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PART 3 — Questions 15–20

Slow Travel: Seeing More by Doing Less

The text has six paragraphs (15–20). Choose the correct heading for each paragraph from the list of headings (A–H) below. There are more headings than paragraphs, so you will not use all of them.

A A cheaper option than many expect	**B** Why getting there matters as much as arriving
C An idea borrowed from the dinner table	**D** Not an option available to everyone
E Becoming a temporary member of the neighbourhood	**F** Spreading the benefits more widely
G The best seasons for unhurried journeys	**H** How technology has changed the way we book trips

15. _____

The idea first appeared in Italy in the late 1980s, when a group of activists protested against the opening of a fast-food restaurant near Rome's Spanish Steps. Their 'slow food' campaign encouraged people to cook with seasonal ingredients and to enjoy meals without hurrying. Before long, writers began to apply the same thinking to holidays. If a meal could be spoiled by speed, they argued, so could a trip. The term 'slow travel' was soon being used to describe a gentler style of tourism that values depth of experience over the number of sights a person manages to tick off.

16. _____

Instead of trying to visit five cities in a week, slow travellers usually choose one place and stay there for a fortnight or more. They often rent an apartment rather than a hotel room, buy bread from the same bakery each morning and shop at the weekly market. After a few days, shopkeepers start to recognise them, and the people next door may invite them in for coffee. Some even sign up for a short language course or volunteer at a community garden. The aim is not to see a town from the outside, but to understand how ordinary residents actually live there.

17. _____

Slow travellers also think differently about transport. Where possible, they avoid short flights and choose trains, buses, ferries or even bicycles. A twelve-hour rail journey across the Alps might seem like a waste of time to a business traveller, but for a slow tourist the changing scenery, the conversations with fellow passengers and the small stations along the way are an essential part of the holiday rather than an obstacle to it. As a bonus, travelling over land produces far lower carbon emissions than flying, which matters to a growing number of environmentally aware tourists.

18. _____

Many people assume that a longer trip must cost more, but the opposite is often true. Apartment owners frequently offer large discounts for weekly or monthly stays, and having a kitchen means visitors can prepare their own meals instead of eating in restaurants every day. Because they move around less, slow travellers also spend far less on tickets and taxis. A recent survey by a European travel website found that tourists who stayed in one place for two weeks spent, on average, around 30 per cent less per day than those who changed accommodation every two or three nights.

19. _____

Supporters say the approach also does good for the places being visited. Mass tourism tends to concentrate visitors in a handful of famous spots, where crowds damage historic sites and push up rents for residents. Slow travellers, by contrast, are more likely to explore quieter villages and to spend their money in family-run guesthouses, small cafés and

independent shops. This means a larger share of what they pay stays in the area instead of going to international hotel chains. Some regions in Portugal and Japan now actively promote longer stays for exactly this reason.

20. _____

Critics, however, point out that this lifestyle is not realistic for most working people. Employees in many countries receive only two or three weeks of paid holiday a year, and parents are usually limited to school vacations. Spending a month in a Tuscan village is far easier for retirees, students or the growing number of 'digital nomads' who can do their jobs from anywhere with an internet connection. For this reason, some writers argue that the movement is often presented in a rather romantic way, ignoring the time and freedom it requires.